



moments. In January, I went to Rashtrapati Bhavan to receive the Arjuna Award. As I waited to walk up to the stage with the President, I remembered my first visit back in 2012. My sports career had only just begun, and I was receiving the National Child Award for winning two medals at the Para Athletics Nationals. I was just 11, with no idea what path lay ahead — whether I'd return to Rashtrapati Bhavan again, or one day win an Arjuna Award.

At that time, all I knew was that I wanted to be a sportsperson and make my country proud. Sports had always interested me. I was the kind of student who studied just enough to avoid a beating. My father had been a wrestler, and my first love was wrestling too. But because of my disability, my back wasn't flexible. Any load led to injuries. I wrestled for a while, but eventually I had to stop. By then, I had already started para-athletics, so athletics became my focus. People often ask me if there was a single turning point when I chose athletics as a career. The truth is, there wasn't. It was a series of steps. Winning my first national medals in 2012 and being invited to Rashtrapati Bhavan gave me huge motivation, because I

received so much support and recognition after that.

I think I've been fortunate to have more highs than lows in my career, though the lows were important too. In 2019, I wasn't sure where things were going. Then came the heartbreak of finishing fourth at the Tokyo Paralympics. I was devastated, but that result was crucial. It showed me how much I needed to improve. Tokyo was my first Paralympics; I had no experience. I didn't know how to throw in the rain or handle the pressure of elite competition. I learned all that in the next two to three years.

After Paris, I moved on quickly. It's important to always have new targets. New goals help you forget the old ones. After Tokyo, I started preparing for the Worlds and the 2024 Paralympics. After Paris, I took a month-and-a-half break, then started training again because the Worlds became my next focus.

Another reason I got serious again was weight. I normally weigh around 57 kg, but I had gained three extra kilos. That was my wake-up call.

Since then, I've competed in two tournaments — the National Championships in Chennai and one in Germany. At the Nationals, I

Rising fame: From a Paralympic podium in Paris to a growing digital fan base, Navdeep's popularity has soared like his javelin. PTI

managed only 39 metres (39.93), but in Germany I improved to 43. I know I can do better, and I'm saving my best for Delhi.

Life has changed a lot since Paris. Para-athletes are finally getting the recognition we never had before. Para sport is being promoted, and athletes like me, once treated as a joke, are now celebrated. People recognise me, call me by name, and want pictures. Instead of laughter, I hear claps. After the Paralympics, appreciation poured in. I was invited to *Kaun Banega Crorepati* (KBC), then *The Great Indian Kapil Show*. Instagram followers kept shooting up.

For a while, it was exciting. But I knew all this was temporary. Followers are temporary. Achievements are permanent. That's why I deleted the app. As long as I keep winning for my country, I'll have people's love. The social media follower count can go up and down, but my achievements should not.

As told to Jonathan Selvaraj